

An *application programming interface (API)* is a specification for how one program asks another program for information. A *graphical user interface (GUI)* is an easy-to-use interface that lets users click elements on the screen. A *command line interface (CLI)* allows users to interact with a program by entering commands in a terminal.

Using a GUI is the simplest way for nontechnical users to interact with a program. For example, a weather website would present information in a browser (a GUI) for general users, but it might also provide an API that technical users can work with to build projects that use real-time weather data.

APIs allow you to pull in data from external resources. Developers working on large, collaborative projects can build their own APIs to design how each program in the project communicates. Designing and building a good API requires experience and planning, but learning to use an API is much simpler.

A CLI enables automation and scripting in a more customizable fashion than with GUIs.